have to take it literally as referring to twenty-one rivers, it is obvious that the Sapta-Sindhu is a sub-set of the wider Vedic landscape. In my view, the Indus and its tributaries were not a part of the Sapta-Sindhu. The Indus has long been considered a ‘male’ river in Indian tradition and would have not been called a sister. Indeed, it is notable that the Indus and its tributaries are never described as ‘of seven sisters’. My hunch is that the Sapta-Sindhu refers only to the Saraswati and its own tributaries. Take for instance the following stanza:

> ‘Coming together, glorious, loudly roaring—
> Saraswati, Mother of Floods, the seventh—
> With copious milk, with fair streams strongly flowing,
> Fully swelled by the volume of their waters’ [23]

My reading of this stanza is that it talks of how six rivers emptied into the Saraswati, the seventh. There are several old river channels in the region, some of which still flow into the Ghaggar during the monsoon season. These include the Chautang (often identified as the Vedic river Drishadvati) and the Sarsuti. The Sutlej and the Yamuna were probably also counted among the Saraswati’s sisters.

If my hunch is right, it would mean that the Sapta-Sindhu was a much smaller area covering modern Haryana and a few of the adjoining districts of eastern Punjab. Incidentally, this area also corresponds to what ancient texts refer to as Brahmavarta—the Holy Land—where Manu is said to have re-established civilization after the flood. The texts define the Holy Land as lying between the Saraswati and the Drishadvati—again roughly Haryana and a bit of north Rajasthan, but excluding most of Punjab. So why was this small area so important? The people of the Sapta-Sindhu were obviously part of a cultural milieu that covered a much larger area. What was so special about these seven rivers? In my view the importance of the Land of the Seven Rivers probably derives from it being the home of the Bharatas, a tribe that would give Indians the name by which they call themselves.